What It Means to Be Human · Part Four of Four

Renewed After the Image

Redemption, Sanctification, and the Restored Person

The Kiln Ministries / Great Physician Application

Sources: Holy Scripture; Calvin, *Institutes*; Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics* / CW; Watson, Boston, Owen, Sibbes

Preface: Picking Up the Thread

Part One showed us what the human being was made to be: an image-bearer of God, crowned with glory, endowed with original righteousness, oriented toward God as his proper end. Part Two showed us what happened to that creature in the fall: the image defaced, the righteousness lost, the mind darkened, the will enslaved, the affections disordered, and every relationship broken at the root. Part Three went back to the garden to show what the fall rejected: the word of God by which man was made to live. The wound is real and deep. But it is not the last word.

Part Four takes up what theologians call the *ordo salutis* — the order of salvation — and asks what God does, in Christ, to address the catastrophe of the fall. Not merely to forgive it, though forgiveness is essential. Not merely to restrain its effects, though God's common grace does that. But to reverse it: to renew the image, restore the righteousness, heal the relationship, and bring the creature to a glory that exceeds even the original condition in Eden.

The pastoral stakes of this installment are high. Biblical counseling is not merely a ministry of accurate diagnosis; it is a ministry of hope grounded in the reality of what God has actually accomplished and is actually doing in the person who has come to faith. The counselor who understands the full scope of redemptive renewal — what it begins, what it continues, and what it will complete — brings not only truth about the problem but truth about the remedy.

I. The Starting Point: A New Heart

The redemptive process does not begin with human effort. It begins with a sovereign act of God that addresses the deepest level of the person's incapacity — the spiritual death identified in Part Two as the fundamental condition of the unregenerate. Before a person can repent, believe, or seek God, God must act.

Ezekiel 36:26-27 states it precisely: 'I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh. And I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes.' Three things are promised: the removal of the old heart, the gift of a new heart, and the indwelling of the Spirit who enables genuine obedience. The initiative is entirely divine. The language is entirely transformative. This is not renovation but re-creation.

Jesus speaks of this as being born from above (John 3:3-8). The birth metaphor is deliberate: birth is something that happens to the person. The infant does not cause its own birth; it is born. So the regenerate person does not cause his own regeneration; he is made alive (Ephesians 2:5) by the sovereign act of the Spirit. Calvin, in *Institutes* III.3, is emphatic: regeneration is not the improvement of the old self but the death of it — and a genuine new creation in its place. The person who has been regenerated is a new creation (2 Corinthians 5:17). The old has passed away; the new has come.

For the biblical counselor, this establishes the irreducibly divine character of the deepest change. Counseling does not produce regeneration. What the counselor can do is bring the Word — the means through which the Spirit ordinarily works — to bear on the person with faithfulness, patience, and prayer, trusting that the Spirit who regenerates does so through the proclamation and application of the gospel.

II. Justification: The Guilt Addressed

Part Two established that the fallen person bears two burdens: guilt (the legal liability of sin before a holy God) and pollution (the corruption of nature that sin has produced). Justification addresses the guilt. It is a forensic act — a declaration, not a process — by which God pronounces the sinner righteous on the basis of Christ's imputed righteousness received through faith.

Calvin defines justification in *Institutes* III.11 as the acceptance of a person by God, who receives him into his favor and regards him as righteous — not on account of any righteousness of his own but solely on account of the righteousness of Christ reckoned to him by grace through faith. This reckoning is complete, immediate, and permanent. The justified person is not on probation; he stands before God in the full righteousness of the Son of God, and that standing cannot be improved or diminished.

Thomas Watson captures the pastoral significance precisely: justification is 'a gracious act of God, whereby he pardons all the sins of, and accepts the person of, the sinner as righteous, for the righteousness of Christ imputed to him, and received by faith.' The double blessing — pardon of all sins, acceptance of the person — addresses the double problem. The guilt is gone. The relationship is restored.

For biblical counseling, justification is the answer to the shame and guilt that so often immobilize the counselee. The person paralyzed by past sin needs not reassurance that his sins were not so serious, nor encouragement to try harder, but the objective reality of justification: that in Christ, his guilt has been addressed completely and finally at the cross. The counselor who grounds hope in the accomplished work of Christ rather than the developing work of the counselee gives a foundation that does not shift with the counselee's performance.

III. The Last Adam and the True Image

The redemptive project as Paul conceives it is not simply the repair of damaged humanity. It is the completion of what humanity was always meant to become — in Christ, the Last Adam, who is the true and perfect image of the invisible God.

Paul draws the contrast between Adam and Christ in Romans 5:12-21 and 1 Corinthians 15:45-49 with great care. Adam was the first man, the federal head of the old humanity, whose act of disobedience brought condemnation to all who are in him. Christ is the last Adam, the federal head of the new humanity, whose act of obedience brings justification and life to all who are in him. But Paul's argument implies something more than symmetry. The Last Adam does not merely restore what the first Adam lost; he brings humanity to a glory that exceeds the original condition. Adam bore the image of the man of dust; the redeemed will bear the image of the man of heaven (1 Corinthians 15:49).

Christ is 'the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation' (Colossians 1:15) and 'the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature' (Hebrews 1:3). He is what Adam was created to image and never fully became. The goal of redemption is stated with crystalline clarity in Romans 8:29: those whom God foreknew he predestined 'to be conformed to the image of his Son.'

IV. Union with Christ: The Ground of All Redemptive Benefits

The benefits of redemption — regeneration, justification, sanctification, glorification — are all grounded in a single reality: union with Christ. Calvin, in *Institutes* III.1, insists that Christ himself is the ground of all that he gives: 'as long as Christ remains outside of us, and we are separated from him, all that he has suffered and done for the salvation of the human race remains useless and of no value for us.'

To be in Christ is the fundamental description of the believer's condition — appearing over 160 times in Paul's letters in various forms. It is union with Christ that grounds justification (his righteousness is imputed to those in him), union with Christ that grounds sanctification (his Spirit conforms them to his image), and union with Christ that grounds glorification (those in him will be raised as he was raised). Bavinck treats union with Christ as the mystical heart of soteriology — mystical not in the sense of vague or experiential, but in the sense of real and Spirit-wrought: a genuine participation in Christ through which the believer's standing, indwelling, and inheritance are all secured.

For biblical counseling, union with Christ has a direct practical implication: the counselee who has come to faith is approaching God in Christ — with the full standing of the Son, covered by his righteousness, indwelt by his Spirit, and guaranteed his inheritance. The counselor who keeps this reality before the counselee is grounding the counselee's identity in the most stable foundation that exists.

V. The Renewed Image: What Redemption Repairs

Part One identified the narrower image of God as consisting in true knowledge, righteousness, and holiness — drawn from Colossians 3:10 and Ephesians 4:24. Part Two showed these were precisely what the fall destroyed. Part Four shows that these are precisely what redemption restores.

Colossians 3:10 — 'the new self, which is being renewed in knowledge after the image of its creator' — establishes that the renewal of the image is both a present reality and an ongoing process. The new self has been put on (perfect tense — a completed act) and is being renewed (present participle — a continuing process). Both are simultaneously true: the decisive break has been made, and the progressive renewal continues.

Ephesians 4:24 adds the moral dimensions: the new self is 'created after the likeness of God in true righteousness and holiness.' What was lost in the fall is being restored through the work of the Spirit — not perfectly and not immediately, but really and progressively. Watson's definition of sanctification follows this structure precisely: 'a gracious work of God's Spirit, whereby, renewing our natures and writing his law in our hearts, he enables us to die unto sin and live unto righteousness.'

VI. Mortification: Putting Sin to Death

John Owen's axiom in *Of the Mortification of Sin* is worth quoting in full: 'Be killing sin or it will be killing you.' Indwelling sin does not remain static in the believer; it is active, seeking occasions, working through the passions, exploiting every weakness. The new birth creates a new principle of life — but the old principle is not simply extinguished. The remainder of this life is, as Paul describes in Galatians 5:17, a conflict between the flesh and the Spirit.

Mortification, for Owen, is not self-laceration or mere willpower. It is the Spirit's work applied through specific means: genuine self-examination, the application of specific gospel truth to the specific temptation, and Spirit-empowered resistance in the moment of temptation.

But mortification must always be accompanied by vivification — the active cultivation of the corresponding grace. You do not merely stop being proud; you actively cultivate humility. You do not merely stop being angry; you actively cultivate gentleness. The negative and positive movements belong together, because the renewed image is not merely the absence of vice but the presence of genuine virtue. For biblical counseling, this transforms the typical encounter: the question is not merely 'what are you doing wrong?' but 'what grace are you failing to cultivate?'

VII. The Remaining Struggle: Indwelling Sin in the Believer

One of the most practically important doctrines for biblical counseling is the believer's remaining corruption. The new birth is real. Justification is complete. And yet, as Paul testifies in Romans 7, the struggle with indwelling sin continues in the regenerate: 'For I do not do what I want, but I do the very thing I hate' (Romans 7:15).

The *Westminster Confession of Faith*, in its treatment of sanctification, explicitly acknowledges that in this life there remains 'a continual and irreconcilable war' between the flesh and the Spirit. This doctrine matters for counseling in at least two ways.

First, it prevents the counselee from concluding that ongoing struggle is evidence of the absence of grace. The very conflict Paul describes in Romans 7 is itself evidence of spiritual life — a spiritually dead person does not war against sin; he simply lives in it. The counselor who recognizes this can offer genuine hope to the counselee devastated by ongoing struggle.

Second, it prevents false expectations about the pace of sanctification. Progress in sanctification is real and is to be expected — but it is progressive, not instantaneous. Lifelong patterns of sin are not typically broken overnight. The counselor who communicates both the reality of progress and the realism of struggle gives the counselee the fullest picture of what the Christian life actually looks like.

VIII. The Community of Renewal: The Church

Sanctification does not take place in isolation. Ephesians 4:11-16 locates the ordinary work of redemptive renewal within the community of the people of God, gathered around Word and sacrament, governed by elders, knit together in genuine love and mutual accountability. The goal is stated in image-bearing terms: 'the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ' — conformity to the image of the Son, achieved through the ministry of the whole body.

Calvin's treatment of the church in *Institutes* IV.1 is direct and pastoral: there is no other way to enter into life unless this mother conceive us in her womb, give us birth, nourish us at her breast, and keep us under her care until, putting off mortal flesh, we become like the angels. The church is not a voluntary association of like-minded believers; it is the God-ordained community within which the Spirit does his ordinary work of maturation.

For biblical counseling, this means the counselee cannot be genuinely served by a process that replaces the church. However faithful the counsel, the counseling relationship is not the church and cannot do what only the church can do. The counselor who genuinely cares for the counselee's spiritual formation will always be directing him toward genuine participation in a local body — toward the preaching of the Word, the sacraments, the fellowship of believers, and the accountability of pastoral oversight.

IX. Glorification: The Completion of the Image

The renewal of the image that begins in regeneration and continues in sanctification will not reach its completion in this life. It reaches its completion in glorification — the final act of redemption in which the redeemed are fully and permanently conformed to the image of the Son.

Paul's great arc in Romans 8:29-30 traces the entire redemptive sequence in a single sentence, ending with glorification in the past tense — so certain is its fulfillment. The content of glorification is stated in 1 John 3:2: 'We know that when he appears we shall be like him, because

we shall see him as he is.' The vision of Christ in his glory is itself the instrument of the final transformation. The image distorted by sin, being progressively renewed by the Spirit in this life, will be perfected in the direct vision of the One whose image it was always meant to bear.

The resurrection of the body is the completion of the redemption of the whole person. The body-soul unity that God created at the beginning, which sin fractured at the fall and which death temporarily tears apart, will be reunited in glory — transformed, perfected, and incorruptible. Bavinck, in *Christian Worldview*, closes his account of the Christian resolution of the great fractures of human existence with this eschatological vision. The discord between thinking and being, being and becoming, becoming and acting will be fully resolved only at the consummation. In Christ, the resolution has begun. In glory, it will be complete.

X. Implications for Soul Care: Counseling Toward Glory

The counselee's identity is settled in Christ. The person who has come to genuine faith is defined not primarily by his sin, his suffering, or his history, but by his union with Christ. The counselor who addresses the person first as a justified, regenerate, Spirit-indwelt child of God is giving the most stabilizing truth available.

Change is genuinely possible — and genuinely costly. Because the Spirit is at work in the regenerate person, real and lasting transformation is not merely theoretically possible; it is promised. But Owen's realism must accompany this hope: change is genuine, progressive, and costly. It requires the hard work of mortification, the patient cultivation of virtue, and the sustained application of the Word over time.

The process has a direction. Sanctification moves, however haltingly, toward conformity to Christ. The counselor's task is to help the counselee move in the right direction: toward repentance, the means of grace, the community of the church, and the habits of mortification and vivification that the Spirit uses to produce genuine renewal.

The body matters. Because the full person — body and soul — is the object of redemption, and because the resurrection of the body is its completion, the physical life of the counselee is not irrelevant to spiritual care. Sleep, food, exercise, physical suffering — these are not merely medical concerns; they are dimensions of the embodied person whom God is in the process of redeeming.

The end is glory. Every counselee who has come to faith in Christ is moving, through every trial and failure and hard-won victory, toward a destination that will make all of it worthwhile. Paul's word in Romans 8:18 is not pious sentiment: 'I consider that the sufferings of this present time are not worth comparing with the glory that is to be revealed to us.' The counselor who keeps this horizon before the counselee is not minimizing present suffering; he is placing it within the frame that gives it its proper meaning.

XI. Conclusion: The Story That Ends in Magnificence

> *'And we all, with unveiled face, beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another. For this comes from the Lord who is the Spirit.' (2 Corinthians 3:18)*

Four installments. One story. A creature made in the image of God — glorious in his original condition, ruined in the fall, renewed in redemption, and destined for a glory that exceeds everything that came before.

Part One showed us the extraordinary dignity of the image-bearer. Part Two showed us the catastrophe of the fall. Part Three took us back to the garden to hear the word that was refused. Part Four has shown us the remedy: not a patch applied to a damaged surface, but a re-creation from within — regeneration giving life to the dead, justification lifting the guilt of the condemned, sanctification progressively renewing the image through the Spirit's work over a lifetime, and glorification completing the work when the children of God are fully conformed to the image of the Son and see him as he is.

This is what it means to be human — not merely what we are, but what we were made to be, what we have become through the fall, and what we shall be through the grace of the One who entered the ruin himself, bore the full weight of it on the cross, and rose from it with a resurrection that guarantees our own.

The Great Physician did not come to treat a broken machine. He came to restore a ruined image-bearer. And he leaves no case unfinished.

> *'He who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ.' (Philippians 1:6)*

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